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Ubena of the Rivers

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Suckling continues for eighteen months to two years in the case of a healthy child, but if the mother thinks her child is delicate she will go on feeding it considerably longer, even till it is three years old. At eight or nine months it begins to take rice and rice gruel in addition to its mother's milk, and if there is plenty of food available, it soon acquires the astounding pot-belly which is a familiar sight among children in Africa!

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The bond between mother and child is not easily or quickly broken when weaning takes place, and the child continues instinctively to turn to the breast for comfort and reassurance. When its mother picks it up, it will begin to suck though there is no longer any milk, simply as a matter of habit. This is especially noticeable if the child is frightened. Immediately it runs howling to be picked up by its mother, and once safely in her arms and with her nipple in its mouth, feeling secure from danger, it observes the world around with sidelong glances and may even suffer with equanimity the near approach of the alarming stranger from whom it fled in terror. Even quite big children, of five or six years, who have long lost the habit of sucking, seem to find comfort when frightened in physical contact with their mother's breasts, clutching them with their hands or burying their faces there.

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Normally, weaning is accomplished very gradually and without recourse to any particular expedients, but if it proves difficult the mother sometimes puts a little pepper on her nipples to discourage the child. Afterwards the practice of sending children on visits to relatives helps to loosen the special tie between

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mother and child, but it is commonly acknowledged by the Wabena themselves that all through life a particularly close bond of sympathy and affection exists between them. The wanderer is drawn home by remembrance of his mother, not of his father; the girl whose husband wants to take her 338 away from her home thinks primarily of her mother's wishes and of obtaining her mother's consent; the secondary home in which children spend more time than in any other and to which their mother most gladly entrusts them is that of her parents. Children of both sexes remain always a little in awe of their father. Even when grown up, they are seldom quite at their ease with him or on terms of such comfortable intimacy as with mother or maternal uncle. The father, proud and fond of them as he may be, is something of a stranger as compared with those others, and a slight atmosphere of formality is perceptible in their relations, an absence of teasing and joking on the part of the child lest the father be angered by lack of respect. This is the more noticeable in that the Mbena is a great tease among those with whom he is thoroughly at his ease. The male relative whom the Wabena regard with most affection is, then, not their father but their mother's brother, on whom the boys in particular look as their best friend and counsellor. Here, however, a reservation must be made regarding those cases where the maternal and paternal relatives are of dissimilar social position; for when one side of the family is, say, of royal blood and the other of common birth, the rank and social influence of different relatives tends to carry greater weight than their actual relationship, and to be the deciding factor in determining the extent of their influence on the younger generation.

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